franchise, his long hair and beard a constant source of annoyance for his wife when he started out in 2017.

Once a regional enterprise, identified by the neck of the woods it came from—Tollywood, Mollywood or Kollywood—the south Indian film has since become a pan-India phenomenon. It perhaps began with S.S. Rajamouli's *Bahubali*, a colossus that overrode all linguistic barriers, satiating the audience's desire for cinematic spectacle and making a star out of his titular hero, Prabhas, who committed four years to the two-film project. Two years of the pandemic did not dissipate the Tamil, Telangana or Andhra audiences' hunger for the big-screen experience. As media analytics company Comscore found out, southern films generated three times more box-office revenue than their Hindi counterparts in 2021, Telugu being the largest contributor, overtaking Hindi for the first time. Six of the 10 films to have earned a billion at the box office in 2020 and 2021 came from the south, four of them Telugu, including Allu Arjun-starrers *Pushpa* (2021) and *Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo*, as well as *Sarileru Neekevvaru* and *Vakeel Saab*. The reach of south Indian films is no longer confined to the 4,441 screens in the five southern states but also the 4,982 screens spread across other parts of India.

THE RISE AND RISE OF ALLU ARJUN

All Allu Arjun and *Pushpa*'s writer-director Sukumar had wanted to do was make a Telugu entertainer. "The idea wasn't to impress the whole country but it was a great by-product," says Allu Arjun. "If your local audience is impressed, then automatically the energy transfers and the aura spreads." But much before his Pushpa stormed the Hindi belt, film audiences were already hooked to Allu Arjun's work, the dubbed versions of his films being huge hits on movie channels Star Gold and Set Max. It's what made Manish Shah of Goldmines Films, a Mumbai-based company, bid for *Pushpa*'s Hindi theatrical, satellite and digital rights. Allu Arjun's films, Shah noted, have cumulatively amassed 1.2 billion views on the eponymous YouTube channel, twice as many of any other hero from South. "He has the potential to be a pan-India star," says Shah. "Whether he will want to work with a Hindi filmmaker is the question." Unlike his peer Mahesh Babu, who recently announced that he had no interest in doing so, Allu Arjun is open to the opportunity. "Acting in Hindi is a little out of my comfort zone for now, but once there is a requirement, I'll go all-out," he says. Incidentally, Allu Arjun owns an apartment in Mumbai.

Born and brought up in Chennai, the Allu family moved to Hyderabad only in 2000. Arjun's grandfather Allu Ramalingaiah was a farmer-turned-actor who appeared in over a thousand films and was known for his roles as a comedian. "He was a struggling actor



ALLU ARJUN SAYS

From the star's candid conversation with INDIA TODAY

An icon star is...
Every act of yours should be iconic, be it dance, fight or act

Cinema you grew up watching
The pucca South Indian mass masala heroes. Rajinikanth, Kamal Haasan, Chiranjeevi, Balkrishna, Nagarjuna, Venkatesh, Mammootty and Mohanlal. In Hindi, it was Govinda, Amitabh Bachchan, Sunny Deol, Anil Kapoor and Mithun Chakraborty

When Allu Arjun isn't shooting...
I'm either watching films in my office or working out in my gym. Half of it is a dance studio where I also practise martial arts

One thing in your wardrobe we're most likely to find: Perfumes. All-time favourite is Creed Aventus

A song you can't get out of your head:
I know I'm tripping on my own song 'Oo Antava Oo Oo Antava'

Favourite cuisine:
Japanese and Mexican

Favourite films:
Forrest Gump, Titanic, Dilwale Dulhania Le Jaayenge, Maine Pyaar Kiya, Jo Jeeta Wohi Sikandar, Karan Arjun